one would expect to hear from a diplomat, but a common enough part of the discourse among the extremists and their apologists.[5]

Correcting the historical record

Chapter 1 discusses Burma's pre-1948 history in detail, but it is useful to set out the broad themes here. The first point to stress, and this is critical to any understanding of the Rohingyas' situation, is that until 1784 the histories of Arakan (now called Rakhine) and Burma were largely separate.[6] This matters because the debate about who lived in Arakan when it was conquered by the British in 1826 (having been part of the Burmese kingdom for a total of forty years out of the previous 500) is fundamental to understanding the modern-day persecution of the Rohingyas. However, and this cannot be overstressed, where people may or may not have lived in 1826 is irrelevant to their entitlement to citizenship today, and the criterion enshrined in the constitution and the statutes of Myanmar flies in the face of international law and the United Nations Charter. Nevertheless, the claims made around the 1826 issue are also false, and there is value in highlighting this fact.

Before dealing with the history of Arakan until Burma's independence, it is useful to very quickly cover the main dynamics in central Burma. The evidence is that the early communities who lived in that region were culturally linked to other parts of South East Asia.[7] Buddhism arrived in the region in stages but had become important by 800 AD.[8] Around this time there were also several waves of migration from Tibet and this saw the spread of an ethnically Tibetan-Burmese culture[9] and resulted in the establishment of the Pagan Kingdom.[10] This was the first state to both unify the entire Irrawaddy Valley and to be strong enough to push both west and east. During the period of its power, the Rakhine people crossed into Arakan and settled in the province.[11] They had retained a degree of independence from the Pagan Kingdom, while maintaining religious and linguistic links to central Burma. As Martin Smith says, 'The Rakhines, as an ethnic group … appear to have come into the territory around the same time as the main body of ethnic Burman migration into the dry zone area of Upper Burma around the 9th or possibly 10th centuries A.D.'[12]